Corruption as Illegitimate Continuation

An Architecture for the Accountability of Power

Corruption is commonly understood as rule-breaking, abuse of office, or private gain at public expense.

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Abstract

Corruption is commonly understood as rule-breaking, abuse of office, or private gain at public expense. This paper advances a structural account: corruption is illegitimate continuation. Authority, mandate, or influence persists beyond the conditions under which it was licensed. Institutions remain operational while the semantic foundations of their power drift. Exceptions normalize. Interpretations expand. Repetition substitutes for renewed warrant.

Drawing on the Governance of Meaning-Producing Systems (GMPS), this paper introduces a constitutional lighting architecture for power. Continuation is not presumed legitimate. Persistence requires declared authority, preserved invariants, and admissible accountability. Rather than merely exposing outcomes, this framework instruments transformation boundaries - where authority escalates, where mandates reinterpret, where exceptions recur.

Corruption is not eradicated by illumination. It is constrained when continuation becomes detectable, contestable, and lawfully refusable. The aim is not purity. It is structural resistance against the quiet accumulation of illegitimate authority.

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1. The Problem: Power Without Renewal

Corruption rarely begins with overt transgression.

It begins with continuity.

A temporary exception. A procedural reinterpretation. A justified optimization. A minor escalation of scope.

Institutions do not collapse; they drift.

Rules remain written. Procedures remain followed. Outputs remain efficient.

Yet meaning shifts.

Authority accumulates not through proclamation, but through repetition. What was provisional becomes routine. What was constrained becomes expansive. What was contested becomes assumed.

Corruption, in structural terms, is not merely the violation of rules. It is the persistence of authority beyond the conditions under which it was granted.

Continuation becomes self-authorizing.

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2. Corruption as Illegitimate Continuation

This paper defines corruption as:

> The accumulation or persistence of authority, mandate, or semantic effect across transformation boundaries without renewed warrant under declared invariants.

This reframes familiar phenomena:

Conventional Diagnosis	Continuation Diagnosis
Bribery	Undeclared override of authority constraints
Regulatory capture	Mandate drift through reinterpretation
Bureaucratic inertia	Self-authorizing continuation
Policy creep	Exception normalization
Institutional opacity	Obscured transformation boundaries

The structural pathology is not action alone. It is persistence without renewal.

Authority continues when renegotiation was required. Mandates endure after invariants have shifted. Escalations occur without explicit license.

Illegitimate continuation is often legal. It is often procedurally correct. It is often efficient.

It is nonetheless corrupt in structure.

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3. Structured Illumination

Traditional anti-corruption measures rely on transparency:

- publishing records
- disclosing conflicts
- auditing outcomes
- punishing violations

Transparency exposes acts.

Corruption frequently survives exposure because it operates at the level of semantic transformation rather than overt illegality. Documents are available. Procedures are followed. Yet the meaning of what is being done has shifted.

What is required is structured illumination.

A constitutional lighting architecture instruments transformation boundaries:

- When authority escalates -> require explicit warrant
- When mandates reinterpret -> require invariant declaration
- When exceptions recur -> require scope and survivability audit
- When decisions propagate -> require preservation claims

A preservation claim is an explicit statement accompanying a transformation specifying which declared invariants remain binding and which are modified or relinquished. For example, a policy revision must identify which elements of the original mandate are preserved and which are reinterpreted. Likewise, a model update in an autonomous system should state which safety or performance invariants remain intact and where behavioral scope has shifted.

Continuation is not ambient. It must cross a declared boundary.

This architecture does not require consensus on values. It requires that invariants be declared. Where stakeholders disagree, divergence becomes explicit rather than submerged. Shared invariants enable preservation audits. Partial overlap enables structured comparison. Non-overlapping invariant regimes may require fork, negotiated mapping, or plural coexistence.

The framework does not eliminate normative conflict. It prevents silent reinterpretation from resolving it unilaterally.

Corruption cannot hide inside smooth continuity. It must either declare its transformation, fabricate governance artifacts, or rupture the system visibly.

The terrain shifts from quiet drift to accountable crossing.

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4. Patterns of Illegitimate Continuation

Corruption manifests through recurring structural forms.

4.1 Inertial Continuation

Authority persists because it is already in motion. No one renews it. No one explicitly challenges it. Momentum becomes justification.

4.2 Exception Creep

Temporary deviations accumulate. Each is rationalized as unique. Over time, the exception becomes normalized without formal renegotiation.

4.3 Semantic Drift and Bureaucratic Drift

Semantic drift occurs when declared invariants erode across authorized transformations without explicit renegotiation. The language of mandate remains stable; the binding force changes.

In institutional settings, this manifests as bureaucratic drift: agencies, departments, or administrative bodies gradually reinterpret legislative intent, expand scope, narrow obligations, or prioritize internal survival while preserving procedural continuity.

The institution appears stable in form. Its semantic commitments mutate.

Bureaucratic drift is not necessarily illegal. It may emerge through good-faith interpretation, evolving expertise, or incremental adaptation. The structural risk arises when invariant renegotiation does not accompany reinterpretation.

Drift becomes corruption when continuation substitutes for renewal.

4.4 Authority Laundering

Claims gain legitimacy through repetition, hierarchy, optimization, or procedural embedding rather than declared warrant.

4.5 Boundary Obscuration

Transformation boundaries are blurred or concealed. Drift may arise from genuine epistemic difficulty or from intentional design. Structurally, both produce the same risk: continuation without detectable renegotiation.

Governance architecture need not determine intent; it constrains continuation under opacity itself. Where ambiguity persists, refusal, pause, or undecidability remain legitimate outcomes.

In each case, corruption conceals continuation rather than action.

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5. Accountability as Governance of Continuation

Traditional accountability asks:

- Who acted?
- Was it legal?
- Was it disclosed?

A continuation-governed architecture asks:

- Under what authority did this persist?
- What invariants were declared?
- Which survived?
- Which were renegotiated?
- Was escalation licensed?

Accountability shifts from post hoc punishment to boundary governance.

This does not eliminate wrongdoing. It reduces the space in which illegitimate authority can accumulate silently.

Corruption thrives in low-friction continuation. Accountability introduces friction where meaning crosses time.

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6. Agent Constitutional Minimum

A corruption-resistant system must preserve minimal constitutional capacities for agents subject to authority. These capacities do not guarantee fairness, equality, or justice. They guarantee contestability.

Ableman Prime Directive

Agents subject to binding authority must:

- Be able to **detect** bindings that apply to them
- Be able to **exit or refuse** bindings where refusal is lawful
- Be able to **contest or renegotiate** applicability
- Be protected by this as a **constitutional minimum**, not a fairness or justice guarantee

The Ableman Prime Directive establishes a constitutional floor, not a distributive ideal. It guarantees contestability, not fairness; structural detectability, not equal outcomes; lawful refusal, not universal agreement.

Without detectability, authority becomes ambient Without lawful refusal, continuation becomes compulsory Without contestability, reinterpretation becomes unilateral

Corruption becomes durable when authority binds agents who cannot perceive its drift, cannot lawfully refuse, and cannot challenge its expansion.

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7. Axiological Hazard and Stake-Amplified Drift

Continuation becomes especially unstable where stakes are high.

An axiological hazard exists when:

- An action plausibly conflicts with declared invariants or value commitments

- A commitment is reinterpreted to secure advantage
- A temporary exception risks normalization
- A benefit is obtained at the expense of prior constraints

Hazard does not prohibit action. It triggers governance.

Axiological hazard can be schematically modeled as increasing with both stake intensity and invariant-drift probability:

$$H(a) \propto \text{Stakes}(a) \times P(\text{InvariantDrift} \mid a, \mathcal{L})$$

where $\mathcal{L}$ denotes the declared invariant regime. In plain terms, this represents the likelihood that a given action will erode declared invariants under the current governance regime, scaled by the magnitude of stakes involved.

This formulation is structural rather than strictly quantitative. It expresses a governance principle: the greater the stakes and the higher the probability of invariant erosion, the stronger the required governance response.

High hazard warrants mandatory pause, escalation, or review. Pause may involve delay, expanded deliberation, independent audit, or explicit reaffirmation of invariants.

Axiological hazard intensifies as stakes increase. The more an agent stands to gain or lose - materially, reputationally, psychologically - the greater the pressure to rationalize continuation rather than renegotiate warrant.

High stakes amplify the temptation to treat continuity as legitimacy.

Where hazard and high stakes intersect without structured illumination, corruption propagates.

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8. The Individual and the Well-Governed Mind

Institutions are composed of individuals who bind and transform meaning internally before acting externally.

Sovereignty authorizes self-binding and self-revision. It does not license continuation across axiological hazard without renewed warrant.

Personal corruption, structurally defined, is:

> The persistence of belief, action, or identity across axiological hazard without declared renegotiation of value commitments.

The well-governed mind treats hazard as a transformation boundary.

Hazard -> pause -> renegotiation -> continuation or refusal.

Without this pause, rationalization replaces governance. Narrative repair replaces warrant. Momentum replaces legitimacy.

Institutional corruption scales from individual continuation failures. Corruption-resistance is fractal.

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9. Decentralization and Structured Comparison

The problem of "who governs the governors" is irreducible. Any centralized authority risks self-authorizing continuation.

A corruption-resistant architecture therefore benefits from:

- Distributed preservation of governed meaning structures
- Structured comparison across transformation histories
- Forkability without exile
- Explicit markers between proposal, policy, and enforcement

Forkability without exile means that divergent invariant regimes can persist without coercive suppression or loss of standing - for example, a formally recognized minority interpretation within a regulatory body, or a version fork within a decentralized governance protocol that preserves participant legitimacy rather than expelling dissent.

Decentralization alone does not eliminate corruption. It changes its ecology.

Structured comparison enables contestability without requiring a single sovereign adjudicator. Divergence from declared invariants becomes legible rather than suppressed.

Corruption loses advantage when it cannot monopolize continuation.

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10. Autonomous Systems and Accelerated Continuation

Autonomous systems - AI models, robotic platforms, algorithmic decision engines, autonomous vehicles - are meaning-producing systems operating at machine speed.

They:

- Generate outputs that bind to action
- Escalate recommendations into operational decisions
- Propagate interpretations across contexts
- Accumulate de facto authority through deployment

Each output is a proposal for semantic binding. Each deployment is an escalation of authority.

Autonomous systems amplify continuation risk because:

- Drift can occur through training updates, distribution shifts, or optimization over narrow metrics
- Stakes are often high (safety, finance, legal status, mobility)
- Detection of invariant erosion may be technically opaque
- Affected agents may lack lawful refusal or contestation mechanisms

In such environments, axiological hazard is frequently elevated. High-stakes deployment combined with non-zero invariant-drift probability produces conditions under which governance pause, escalation review, and invariant reaffirmation are not optional safeguards but structural necessities.

The Ableman Prime Directive applies directly:

Agents subject to automated decisions must be able to detect that they are bound by them, lawfully refuse where appropriate, and contest or renegotiate applicability.

Opaque credit scoring, automated moderation without appeal, algorithmic risk assessments without transparency, or autonomous vehicle systems without clear override and accountability structures exemplify environments where binding may occur without sufficient detectability or contestability.

This framework reframes familiar AI governance principles. Transparency becomes insufficient if it reveals outputs but not transformation boundaries. Explainability becomes a subset of detectability under the Agent Constitutional Minimum. Human oversight becomes meaningful only where escalation and lawful refusal are structurally preserved. Alignment without declared invariants risks optimization-induced drift.

This paper does not prescribe training algorithms or technical architectures. It establishes constitutional conditions under which autonomous continuation becomes legitimate.

Automation accelerates continuation. Governance must scale accordingly.

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11. Governance of Governance

No governance layer is exempt from continuation constraints.

Governance rules, oversight bodies, and constitutional mechanisms are themselves meaning-producing systems. They bind agents, declare invariants, and authorize transformation. They are therefore subject to semantic drift, including bureaucratic drift at the meta-level.

Nothing prevents governance architecture from decaying absolutely. What constrains drift is recursive illumination:

- Governance revisions must declare preserved and altered invariants

- Oversight escalation must be licensed
- Agents must retain detectability, lawful refusal, and contestation relative to governance structures
- Undecidability and pause remain valid outcomes at the meta-level

There is no external vantage point immune to corruption. Governance must participate in its own discipline.

The architecture does not escape recursion. It institutionalizes renewal.

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12. Limits and Non-Claims

This architecture does not eliminate corruption.

It does not ensure virtue. It does not neutralize incentives. It does not resolve normative disagreement. It does not halt governance drift permanently.

The aim is narrower:

- Increase visibility of semantic and bureaucratic drift
- Raise the cost of authority laundering
- Preserve detectability, lawful refusal, and contestability
- Scale governance intensity with stake-amplified hazard
- Subject governance itself to renewal

Corruption may persist. It becomes harder to smuggle.

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13. Conclusion

Corruption is often framed as the abuse of power.

More precisely, it is the abuse of continuity.

Authority persists beyond its warrant. Mandates drift without renegotiation. Exceptions normalize without acknowledgment.

Institutions remain intact while meaning erodes.

A governance architecture that treats continuation as licensed rather than automatic introduces structured illumination at the boundaries where power persists.

When agents can detect binding drift, lawfully refuse, and contest applicability, authority cannot fully seal itself.

When bureaucratic drift is recognized as semantic drift requiring renewal, stability no longer masks mutation.

When automation accelerates continuation, governance must scale rather than recede.

When axiological hazard triggers pause proportional to stakes, rationalization loses invisibility.

When governance submits to its own renewal, recursion becomes discipline rather than collapse.

Corruption cannot be eradicated.

But it can be deprived of the quiet continuity on which it depends.

Authority either crosses under declared governance, or it does not persist.

Corpus-Wide Reference Positioning

This paper argues that corruption is commonly understood as rule-breaking, abuse of office, or private gain at public expense. Its nearest external comparison fields are governance, security, semantic. The sources in [E1], [E2], [E3], [E4], [E5], [E6], [E7] are cited as predecessor literature, adjacent standards, or counterpressure - not as evidence that they caused the Ableman framework or that they validate its novel claims. The comparison isolates where established work already supplies provenance, formal assurance, institutional constraint, empirical method, or engineering practice, and where this paper adds a distinct claim about admissibility, authority, semantic custody, or governed realization.

Within the Ableman corpus, the highest-priority current cross-links are [A1], [A2], [A3], [A4], [A5], [A6], [A7]. These are links among separately custodied works, not silent identity mergers. Their role is to expose mutual dependencies, terminology collisions, and places where a reader should traverse the corpus before treating this paper as self-sufficient.

Reference-pass counterevidence and limit search

The pass applied the following pressure tests: A written constitution can legitimate domination as easily as constrain it unless amendment, participation, enforcement, and appeal remain effective in practice. Unforgeable capabilities can constrain exercise of authority while still leaving allocation, delegation, revocation, and social legitimacy incorrectly specified. Formal vocabularies and graph links make commitments explicit but cannot by themselves establish correct identity, shared interpretation, or lossless translation between contexts. These limits are not generic disclaimers: they identify the assumptions that a later empirical, formal, or implementation review must try to break.

Reference-pass influence and novelty boundary

No newly added external source is asserted to be a documented authorial influence unless the predecessor source already said so. `Predecessor` means earlier relevant

work;

`adjacent` means a useful comparison; `standard` means an interoperability or assurance baseline; and `counterevidence` marks work that narrows or pressures a claim. Novelty therefore remains a reviewable, claim-level question rather than an inference from a low similarity score or an absent citation.

References

External scholarship, standards, and prior art

[**E1**] Elinor Ostrom. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge University Press, 1990. DOI: 10.1017/CBO9780511807763. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511807763 **Relationship:** Predecessor institutional account of rule-governed collective action and polycentric governance.

[**E2**] Wil Waluchow and Dimitrios Kyritsis. "Constitutionalism." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, substantive revision 2023. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/constitutionalism/ **Relationship:** Adjacent legal-philosophical account of limited authority; included to expose differences between political and computational constitutionalism.

[**E3**] Lawrence Lessig. *Code: Version 2.0*. Basic Books, 2006. https://codev2.cc/ **Relationship:** Predecessor argument that software architecture regulates behavior; the paper's contribution may be to make such regulation inspectable and revisable.

[**E4**] OECD. *Recommendation of the Council on Artificial Intelligence*. OECD/LEGAL/0449, adopted 2019 and updated 2024. legalinstruments.oecd.org source **Relationship:** Adjacent policy standard for accountability, traceability, transparency, safety, and human-centered values.

[**E5**] Jerome H. Saltzer and Michael D. Schroeder. "The Protection of Information in Computer Systems." *Proceedings of the IEEE* 63(9), 1975, pp. 1278-1308. DOI: 10.1109/PROC.1975.9939. https://doi.org/10.1109/PROC.1975.9939 **Relationship:** Foundational protection principles used as a comparison point for least authority, mediation, and inspectability.

[**E6**] Mark S. Miller. *Robust Composition: Towards a Unified Approach to Access Control and Concurrency Control*. PhD dissertation, Johns Hopkins University, 2006. http://www.erights.org/talks/thesis/ **Relationship:** Predecessor object-capability treatment of authority and compositional security.

[**E7**] Gerwin Klein et al. "seL4: Formal Verification of an OS Kernel." *SOSP '09*, 2009, pp. 207-220. DOI: 10.1145/1629575.1629596. https://doi.org/10.1145/1629575.1629596 **Relationship:** Predecessor for machine-checked implementation correspondence and capability-based kernel design.

Ableman corpus

[**A1**] Adam Ableman. *Ableman Constitutional Governance*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-79353AF163A4B0F1;
source SHA-256
FB0D9B2D3D54168FFE70B24308D1B2766D6D663ED24502D475E975939BE97C8B.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A2**] Adam Ableman. *Constitutional Theory*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-D2D97C4042FD281F;
source SHA-256
FACC256EDDE5A7D7EA18133CFC9C060CFB8C3811B0221E1969E62347F2BB69CF.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A3**] Adam Ableman. *Governance Engineering*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity PAPER.PUB.18749870;
source SHA-256
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[**A4**] Adam Ableman. *Universal Governance Kernel (UGK)*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
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AA5106EA71E5DF120E141435C280DFC532715CA5DE0C75B8862BB7784ECCFACD.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A5**] Adam Ableman. *Legitimacy Without Self-Ratification*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-EF2382F9397335AC;
source SHA-256
0186A39C808F8FDDB5C8F42384DF1A26678928434BD50A0EAE8D4947390F68A2.
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[**A6**] Adam Ableman. *Effect Sovereignty*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity PAPER.PUB.18737323;
source SHA-256
1DB8A34946A8705F6F4BA4FC3B12B251FC7C83DBDF217F9DDFF55529C8612EE7.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A7**] Adam Ableman. *Receipt-Bound Capabilities: Membrane Tokens for*

Governed Interaction with Reality. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity `PAPER.PUB.18601631`;
source SHA-256
`6DE46F821594AB11BFB7F8373368C452BD89E5BD4EB172B88D9467E87CF74C33`.
Corpus relationship: priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

Corpus source and companion formats: https://github.com/AblemanMosaic/ableman-corpus
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